The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

4th February 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Tepid (निष्क्रिय)

Meaning: Lacking enthusiasm or conviction; lukewarm
Synonyms: Unenthusiastic, indifferent, half hearted
Antonyms: Enthusiastic, passionate, eager
Example: The new policy received a tepid response from the public, with only a few showing interest in its implementation.

2. Intermittent (रुक-रुक कर होने वाला)

Meaning: Occurring at irregular intervals; not continuous
Synonyms: Sporadic, occasional, periodic
Antonyms: Continuous, constant, unceasing
Example: The intermittent supply of electricity made it difficult for factories to function efficiently.

VOCABULARY

3. Precarious (अनिश्चित)

Meaning: Not secure; dependent on uncertain conditions
Synonyms: Unstable, insecure, risky
Antonyms: Secure, stable, safe
Example: The precarious economic situation made investors hesitant to put their money into the market.

4. Roiled (उलझन में डालना)

Meaning: To disturb or cause turmoil
Synonyms: Agitate, disturb, unsettle
Antonyms: Calm, soothe, settle
Example: The sudden changes in trade policies roiled global markets, leading to panic among investors.

VOCABULARY

5. Retaliatory (प्रतिशोधात्मक)

Meaning: Done as a response to a perceived wrong; revengeful
Synonyms: Revengeful, vengeful, retributive
Antonyms: Forgiving, conciliatory, merciful
Example: The country imposed retaliatory tariffs in response to trade restrictions placed by its neighbor.

6. Deleterious (हानिकारक)

Meaning: Causing harm or damage
Synonyms: Harmful, detrimental, injurious
Antonyms: Beneficial, helpful, advantageous
Example: Smoking has a deleterious effect on health, increasing the risk of lung diseases.

VOCABULARY

7. Panacea (सर्वरोगहारी उपाय)

Meaning: A solution or remedy for all problems or difficulties
Synonyms: Cure-all, universal remedy, elixir
Antonyms: Problem, ailment, affliction
Example: Many believe that technological advancements are a panacea for all economic challenges.

8. Envisage (परिकल्पना करना)

Meaning: To imagine or expect something as a future possibility
Synonyms: Foresee, anticipate, predict
Antonyms: Ignore, disregard, neglect
Example: The project envisages a significant reduction in carbon emissions over the next decade.

VOCABULARY

9. Overwhelming (अत्यधिक , भारी भरकम)

Meaning: Very great in amount or intensity
Synonyms: Staggering, immense, tremendous
Antonyms: Insignificant, minor, trivial
Example: The overwhelming dependence on China for solar panels has slowed India's renewable energy progress.

10. Prerogative (विशेषाधिकार)

Meaning: A special right or privilege exclusive to a particular individual or group
Synonyms: Privilege, right, entitlement
Antonyms: Obligation, duty, restriction
Example: It is the prerogative of the government to impose tariffs to protect domestic industries.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Bang up
Meaning – To damage or injure severely

2. Barge in
Meaning – To enter rudely or abruptly

3. Belt out
Meaning – To sing or play loudly and forcefully

4. Black out
Meaning – To lose consciousness or experience a power failure

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. Water under the bridge

Meaning – A past event that is no longer important or worth worrying about

2. As blind as a bat

Meaning – Having very poor eyesight or being unaware of something

3. One-horse town

Meaning – A small, unimportant, or dull town

VOCABULARY

4. On a shoestring

Meaning – With a very limited budget or resources

5. Clear the air

Meaning – To resolve misunderstandings or ease tension through discussion

Article for Reading

Tariff turmoil: on Trump and punishing tariffs on trade

President Donald Trump set the cat among the pigeons globally when he introduced a slew of punishing tariffs on trade with Canada, Mexico, and China, with even more taxes promised for other trading partners in the months ahead. Markets in Japan, South Korea and across Asia were roiled as fears peaked of the fallout on supply chains for North America, particularly in sectors such as automobiles, which have enjoyed the strong presence of foreign investment for decades. Over the weekend, Mr. Trump signed three executive orders that slapped Canadian and Mexican goods with a tariff of 25%. Only Canadian energy products were spared — a 10% tax will be applied. The White House further announced, in line with the promises Mr. Trump made on the campaign trail, a 10% tax on goods from China.

Beijing responded angrily, saying that it would file a lawsuit with the WTO against the U.S. for “wrongful practice”, even as it said that it would take “necessary countermeasures....” While Ottawa and Mexico City warned that retaliatory tariffs would be coming soon, Mr. Trump’s subsequent calls to Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum led to a one-month pause before the tariffs kicked in, and the White House appeared to strike a conciliatory note with Mr. Trump speaking to Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau as well. Meanwhile, Mr. Trump has suggested that the EU was next in the firing line, even though the U.K. appeared to win a modicum of a reprieve for issues with Washington. While tariffs are traditionally applied sparingly, and mostly in cases of trade imbalances in the context of artificial price barriers imposed by one country that impact its trading partners, the official reasoning supplied by the Trump White House for its tariff plan was that it would serve to address the “national emergency” resulting from “the extraordinary threat posed by illegal aliens and drugs, including deadly fentanyl”.

On one hand, this opens the floodgates to other nations retaliating to U.S. tariffs and dampening world trade at a time when global economic growth prospects are precarious. The move also signals that it is acceptable for nations to weaponise tariffs as a countermeasure against unrelated inter-country disputes. Few would deny Mr. Trump's administration the prerogative that it enjoys to crackdown on the U.S.'s "ridiculous Open Borders" — but most would have imagined that this process would entail intensified law enforcement activity rather than internecine tariffs. The tariffs will almost certainly have a deleterious effect on the prices that American consumers pay for imported products, besides a broader inflationary impact through higher input prices across industries. Perhaps it will take a full four years of economic pain in the U.S. before the realisation dawns that tariffs are hardly a panacea to curb immigration and drug inflows.

Summary

Former U.S. President Donald Trump imposed hefty tariffs on trade with Canada, Mexico, and China, sparking global economic concerns. The tariffs—25% on Canadian and Mexican goods (excluding energy products, which faced a 10% tax) and 10% on Chinese imports—triggered retaliatory threats from affected nations. Markets across Asia reacted negatively, fearing disruptions in global supply chains, particularly in the automobile sector. While Trump justified the tariffs as a response to illegal immigration and drug trafficking, the move risked escalating trade conflicts and increasing prices for American consumers. The long-term effectiveness of tariffs as a tool for addressing non-trade issues remains questionable.

Tone:

The tone is critical, analytical, and cautionary, highlighting the economic risks and unintended consequences of Trump's tariff policies.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
What does the passage suggest about the long-term economic impact of Trump's tariff policy on the U.S.?

a) The tariffs will lead to an immediate economic boost, reducing inflation and strengthening domestic industries
b) The tariffs will curb illegal immigration and drug trafficking as intended, without any significant side effects
c) The tariffs will increase the cost of imported goods, contribute to inflation, and likely cause economic hardship in the U.S.
d) The tariffs will force China and Mexico to comply with all U.S. trade demands, making the policy a success
e) None of the above

Question 2:
Why is the use of tariffs as a tool to combat illegal immigration and drug trafficking considered problematic in the passage?

a) It is an ineffective solution, as tariffs primarily impact trade and not border security issues
b) The tariffs disproportionately harm Canada while leaving China unaffected
c) It strengthens diplomatic ties between the U.S. and its trade partners but weakens domestic industries
d) It allows Mexico and Canada to gain trade advantages over the U.S.
e) None of the above

Question 3:
What was the immediate global reaction to President Trump's introduction of new tariffs?

a) Increased confidence in global trade as the U.S. sought to protect domestic industries
b) Widespread economic optimism in Canada and Mexico due to the delay in tariff imposition
c) A sharp reduction in U.S. imports from Canada and Mexico, immediately improving the U.S. trade balance
d) Market instability, especially in Asia, due to fears of disrupted supply chains
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

Green and clean: on India and a critical minerals framework

India has come a long way in its attempt to transition to cleaner forms of power in the past decade. This is partly reflected in the budgetary allocation to the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy between fiscal years 2015 (BE ₹1,535 crore) and 2025 (BE ₹32,626 crore). But these allocations, other than in 2015 and 2023, have been underutilised, leading to lower revised estimates (REs). However, this does not fully reflect the clean energy journey. India attempted a major leap with the PM-KUSUM scheme in 2019, a year ahead of the COVID-19 disruptions, with an outlay of ₹34,422 crore. The scheme envisaged having off-grid solar irrigation pumps and grid-connected solar plants on fallow farmlands. While PM-KUSUM has received a tepid response, with less than half a gigawatt of installed capacity, the realisation that energy transition is both a desirable outcome and a requirement occurred during the COVID-19 years, when there were major supply chain disruptions to coal, oil and gas.

This led to India pledging to produce half its energy requirements from renewables in about five years from now, at COP26 in 2021. It was the 2021 Budget that heralded the clean energy shift, with ₹18,100 crore for a PLI scheme for advanced chemistry cell manufacturing to augment India's grid-scale battery storage capacity. A ₹4,500 crore PLI scheme for solar photovoltaic modules went up to ₹19,500 crore in 2022. But the government also decided to levy a 40% basic customs duty (BCD) on solar modules and 25% on solar cells to reduce the overwhelming import dependence on China. However, this slowed solar power installations nationwide with prices rising. And even while renewables constitute 46% of India's total installed capacity (October 2024), 70% of its power output is from coal. Experts have pointed to the need for grid-scale battery storage technology to augment India's renewables output, as intermittent RE production leads to the continued reliance on fossil-fuel based power.

With the realisation that steep BCDs could be inflationary and counterproductive to localising production, particularly in the capital-intensive lithium-ion battery technology sector, the government has announced that it will exempt 12 critical minerals and 35 capital goods from BCDs. But reducing dependence on China for energy transition resources and technology would also require India showing leadership in formulating a critical minerals framework, that is socially and environmentally just during extraction, and equitable in its distribution. With the U.S. withdrawing its leadership position in these areas, India must aim to play a bigger role.

Question 4:
What challenge does India face in reducing dependence on China for energy transition resources?

a) Lack of skilled workforce for manufacturing renewable energy components
b) Absence of a robust framework for critical minerals extraction and distribution
c) Limited solar energy potential due to unfavorable climatic conditions
d) High domestic production of fossil fuels making transition unnecessary
e) None of the above

Question 5
Why did the government decide to exempt 12 critical minerals and 35 capital goods from BCDs?

a) To boost India's domestic coal production
b) To encourage foreign direct investment in the fossil fuel industry
c) To make lithium-ion battery production less capital-intensive and more competitive
d) To increase reliance on China for energy transition technology
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question

Original Text:

India is highly vulnerable to various natural and man-made disasters due to its geographical diversity and large population. Earthquakes, floods, cyclones, droughts, and industrial accidents frequently impact different regions, causing significant loss of life and property. Effective disaster management is crucial for minimizing damage and ensuring rapid recovery. The Government of India has taken several initiatives to strengthen disaster preparedness and response. The Disaster Management Act, 2005 established the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) to formulate policies, coordinate relief efforts, and enhance disaster resilience.

Additionally, institutions like the Indian Meteorological Department (IMD) and National Remote Sensing Centre (NRSC) provide early warnings for cyclones, floods, and earthquakes, helping in timely evacuation andmitigation efforts. Disaster management in India follows a four-phase approach: Mitigation – Reducing disaster risks through infrastructure improvements, afforestation, and climate adaptation strategies. Preparedness – Conducting awareness campaigns, training programs, and mock drills for effective response. Response – Providing emergency aid, search and rescue operations, and medical assistance during disasters. Recovery – Rebuilding infrastructure, rehabilitating affected communities, and restoring livelihoods post-disaster. Despite these efforts, challenges remain, including inadequate infrastructure in rural areas, slow disaster relief distribution, and lack of public awareness. Strengthening early warning systems, investing in resilient infrastructure, and community participation can enhance India's disaster preparedness and response capabilities.

Precis:

India faces frequent natural and man-made disasters, requiring robust disaster management. The Disaster Management Act, 2005 established NDMA to oversee disaster preparedness and response, supported by agencies like IMD and NRSC for early warnings.

India follows a four-phase approach: mitigation, preparedness, response, and recovery. While government initiatives have improved disaster resilience, challenges like infrastructure gaps and slow relief efforts persist. Strengthening early warning systems, infrastructure, and community engagement is essential for better disaster management.

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Subject: Confirmation of Attendance – Request for Schedule and Venue Details

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I hope this email finds you well. I am writing to confirm my attendance at the [Seminar Name] scheduled for [Date]. I appreciate the opportunity to participate and look forward to gaining valuable insights from the event.

Could you kindly share the detailed schedule and venue information if it has been finalized? Additionally, please let me know if there are any specific requirements or materials I should bring.

Thank you for your assistance. I look forward to the seminar.

Best regards,
[Your Name]
[Your Contact Information]

Match the column

1. Water under the bridge	A. A small, unimportant, or dull town
2. As blind as a bat	B. With a very limited budget or resources
3. One-horse town	C. To resolve misunderstandings through discussion
4. On a shoestring	D. A past event that is no longer important
5. Clear the air	E. Having very poor eyesight or being unaware of something

Answer:

1-d

2-e

3-a

4-b

5-c

Vocabulary

1. Tepid:
2. Intermittent:
3. Precarious:
4. Roiled:
5. Retaliatory:
6. Deleterious:
7. Panacea:
8. Envisage:
9. Overwhelming:
10. Prerogative:

RC ANS

1.

Ans: c

Explanation:

Reference: "The tariffs will almost certainly have a deleterious effect on the prices that American consumers pay for imported products, besides a broader inflationary impact through higher input prices across industries."

The passage states that tariffs will likely have a deleterious effect on U.S. consumers, leading to higher prices for imported goods and broader inflationary impacts across industries.

Incorrect Options:

a) The passage suggests the opposite, warning of economic pain rather than a boost.

b) There is skepticism that tariffs can curb immigration and drug trafficking effectively.

d) The passage does not suggest that other countries will simply comply; rather, it hints at retaliatory measures.

2.
Ans: a
Explanation:
Reference: "Few would deny Mr. Trump’s administration the prerogative that it enjoys to crack down on the U.S.’s 'ridiculous Open Borders' — but most would have imagined that this process would entail intensified law enforcement activity rather than internecine tariffs."

The passage argues that using tariffs to address immigration and drug issues is misguided because tariffs primarily affect trade and industry, not law enforcement. The author suggests that a more appropriate solution would involve intensified law enforcement rather than economic measures.

Incorrect Options:

b) The passage does not claim that Canada suffers disproportionately while China remains unaffected.
c) The policy appears to strain, not strengthen, diplomatic ties.
d) The passage does not suggest that Canada or Mexico will benefit from the tariffs.

3.
Ans: c
Explanation:
Reference: "Markets in Japan, South Korea and across Asia were roiled as fears peaked of the fallout on supply chains for North America, particularly in sectors such as automobiles."

The passage states that markets in Japan, South Korea, and across Asia were roiled due to concerns about supply chain disruptions, especially in sectors like automobiles, which have long relied on foreign investment.

Incorrect Options:

a) The tariffs led to uncertainty and instability, not confidence in global trade.
b) While Mexico secured a one-month pause, the overall reaction was negative, not optimistic.
d) The passage does not state that U.S. imports immediately declined—retaliatory measures were still being considered.

4.
Ans: b
Explanation:
Reference: "Reducing dependence on China for energy transition resources and technology would also require India showing leadership in formulating a critical minerals framework."

The passage emphasizes that India needs a well-defined critical minerals framework that is socially and environmentally just. Without this, reducing dependence on China will be difficult.

Incorrect Options:

a) The passage does not mention workforce shortages as a major issue.
c) India has high solar potential, and the passage does not cite climatic issues.
d) India still relies on fossil fuels, but the transition is necessary.

5.

Ans: c

Explanation:

Reference: "With the realisation that steep BCDs could be inflationary and counterproductive to localising production, particularly in the capital-intensive lithium-ion battery technology sector, the government has announced that it will exempt 12 critical minerals and 35 capital goods from BCDs."

The passage mentions that steep BCDs were counterproductive to localizing production in capital-intensive lithium-ion battery technology. Exempting critical minerals and capital goods helps lower costs and encourage domestic manufacturing.

Incorrect Options:

a, b, d are unrelated to the exemption decision.

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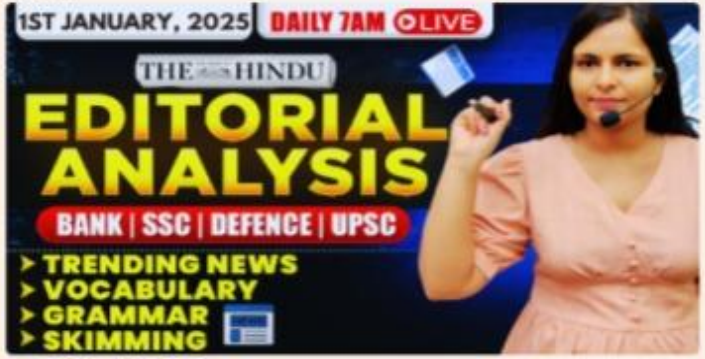

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